



A survey conducted by the National Council for Applied Economic Research (NCAER) says 63.3 per cent of Chhattisgarh's population is below the poverty line—the highest in the country.

The per capita energy consumption of Chhattisgarh is above the national average and is expected to cross 1,000 units by the end of current fiscal.

For an energy surplus state, a massive investment in transmission and distribution network is required to prevent load-shedding due to systems failure.

RAMAN AT A PDS LAUNCH SCHEME

a second term, the challenge was to plug leakages from the public distribution system (PDS) that had the potential to waylay the gains.

That's where a novel e-governance initiative helped. The state's 26 lakh ration card holders can register their mobile numbers on a toll-free helpline at a call-centre after which they receive a text message every time a truck leaves with rations from the State Civil Supplies Corporation warehouse for the fair price shop. "Within a day, a card-holder can inquire from the fair price shop about the arrival of the rations," says N. Bajendra Kumar, principal secretary, Food and Civil Supplies. At the back-end, the department has digitised the database of 10,500-odd fair price outlets and card-holders, eliminating discretion. With such measures, pilferage has come down considerably.

However, the challenges Raman faces are daunting. According to the latest survey of poverty by the National Council for Applied Economic Research (NCAER), Chhattisgarh has an unflattering 63.3 per cent people below the poverty line, the highest in the country, followed by Jharkhand at 49 per cent and Madhya Pradesh at 45.5 per cent. "The real challenge is ensuring trickle-down effect of the turn-

around in the state's economic scene," says Raman. His power policy could provide him sufficient financial heft to launch a raft of new programmes for poverty-eradication, welfare and capacity building. Raman's critics, however, most notably within the BJP, sense that his power policy is the best way to chip away at his growing stature. At least two senior party MPs have consistently approached the BJP brass in Delhi with complaints that corporates and IPPs were being given a free run and the state's family silver in the form of coal was being palmed off without due diligence.

While these charges haven't stuck so far, some emerging trends in the state's uneasy politics signal other troubles for Raman. Chhattisgarh's once friction-free society is beginning to witness political polarity around caste. After Panchayat and Rural Development Minister Ramvihar Netam recently manhandled a State Administrative Service (SAS) officer in Bilaspur, not just his colleagues in service but community organisations of his Devangan oBC community rallied around him against the tribal minister's intemperate act.

Last year, the sons of a senior oBC member of the Raman Cabinet, Chandrashekhar Sahu, had roughed

up another official. While his own instincts would have prompted him to get rid of such ministers, the twin factors of their respective castes and lack of efficient replacements has tied Raman's hands. With just 49 MLAs to choose from in a house of 90, Raman can't cast his net wide for unearthing efficient administrators while still maintaining a caste balance in his Cabinet. The lack of choice has saddled him with most of the key portfolios like general administration, mining, energy and finance.

Raman is a Rajput chief minister in a state dominated by tribals (34 per cent) and oBCs (52 per cent) and out of sheer political exigency, is trying to take the sting out of caste polarisation. He has also attempted to blunt the local versus outsider issue by proposing a new law to prevent non-domicile citizens from buying agricultural land in the state.

With the odds like mass poverty in the state facing Raman, the chief minister may be overcome with big-ticket spending on welfare programmes once his policies begin to rake in the cash. But much will depend upon how Raman, the politician tackles intangibles like caste-driven politics which may perhaps set the tone for his political future. ■